BMS-01 · WORLD & INDIAN HISTORY · MID-TERM

History Midsem: Exam Essentials

The short, simple version. Only what you can actually use in exam answers, explained in plain words with an example for every idea. Sessions 1–4 and 6–11 (Session 5 is not in the syllabus).

How to use this guide (read in 1 minute)

Each session has the same 5 parts

1. **In one line**: the whole session in one sentence. If you remember nothing else, remember this.
2. **Picture it**: a diagram or map.
3. **Key ideas**: **keyword** → what it means in simple words → an **e.g.**
4. **Names & dates**: only the ones worth writing in an answer.
5. **Write it like this**: a ready model answer you can adapt.

The exam (Lecture 16)

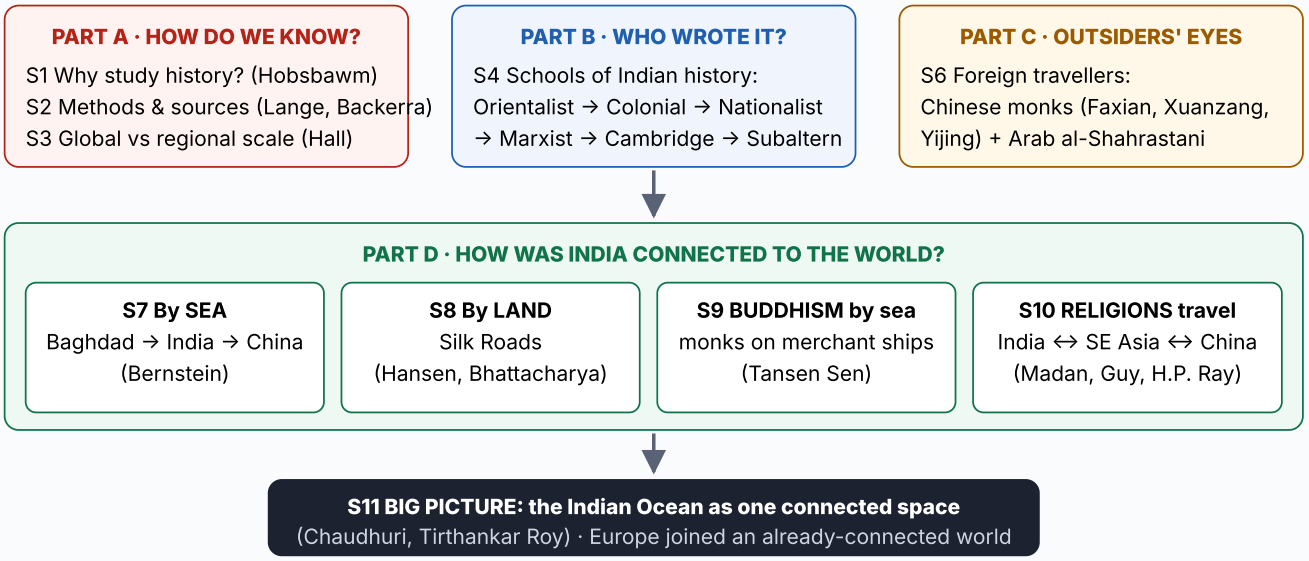
- **Part A**: 10 MCQs × ½ mark = **5**
- **Part B**: answer 3 of 5 short questions × 10 = **30**
- **Part C**: 1 essay out of 2–3 × 15 = **15**
- Total **50 marks**, 2 hours, closed book.

The professor wants: paragraphs (not bullet points), the **name of the scholar**, at least one **example** (a place, person or date), and a short **critical point** ("but…").

THE 4-STEP FORMULA FOR EVERY ANSWER

1. Say what the scholar argues in one line ("Hobsbawm argues that…"). **2. Explain 2–3 points**, each with an example. **3. Add one "but"** (a limitation or criticism). **4. End with one line** linking to the big course idea (e.g. "this shows that India was connected long before Europe arrived").

The whole course on one page



Read top to bottom: first how history is done, then who wrote India's history, then how India was linked to Asia.

FIVE IDEAS THAT APPEAR AGAIN AND AGAIN (USE THEM IN ANY ESSAY)

1. **People use the past for present needs** (Hobsbawm).
   e.g. Nationalists praised ancient India; China's Belt and Road uses the old "Silk Road" name.
2. **Every source has a point of view, so check it against other sources.**
   e.g. al-Shahrastani never visited India, so trust al-Biruni more.
3. **The scale you choose changes the story.**
   e.g. Vasco da Gama looks different from Indian, Indian Ocean and world viewpoints.
4. **Asia was connected long before Europeans came.**
   e.g. Arab, Gujarati and Tamil merchants traded from Africa to China.
5. **Religion travelled with traders and changed on the way.**
   e.g. Buddhist monks sailed on merchant ships to China.

SESSION 1

Why Study History?

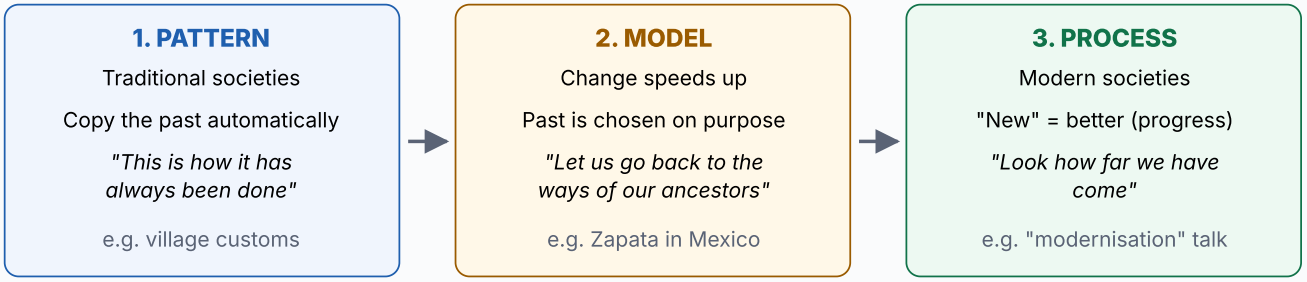
Hobsbawm, "The Social Function of the Past" (1972) + *On History* ch. 3 (via the PPT)

IN ONE LINE

Every society uses its past. The question is not *whether* it does, but *how*: as a pattern to copy, a model to choose from, or a process that leads to today.

Who: Eric Hobsbawm, a British Marxist historian. Key quote: *"The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness."* In simple words, no person or society can escape its past; we live inside it "as fish do in water".

Picture it: three ways a society uses its past



The faster a society changes, the more it moves from left to right.

Key ideas

1. Past as PATTERN

In traditional societies, each generation **copies** the last one. Custom is law.

But they are not frozen. Hobsbawm calls "static traditional society" a **myth**. Change happens quietly, hidden inside old forms.

e.g. Nomads who traded camels started trading lorries and saw it as the same old business. The new thing was fitted into the old pattern.

2. Past as MODEL

When change becomes too fast, people can no longer copy the past automatically. So they **pick parts of it** and say "let's return to that".

Key point: loud calls to "go back" show that the old way has **already broken**.

e.g. Zapata (Mexico): peasants of Morelos fought to restore their old village lands. They could not truly go back, and their fight turned into a **revolution** that created a new Mexico.

3. Restoration: effective vs symbolic

Effective = trying to bring back the real old practices. **Symbolic** = bringing back only the **feeling or symbol** of the past.

e.g. Effective: "bring back old-time religion" (everyone in church). Symbolic: **rebuilding Warsaw's old town** after WWII, or pulling down the Stalin statue in Prague.

4. Invented (fabricated) past

If the past is very old, it becomes a **story used for today's goals**. It can be partly made up but still powerful. **Nationalism** is the best example: nations "get their history wrong" (Renan).

e.g. The new country "Ghana" took the name of an old empire from a different place. Indian nationalists praised a "golden age" (Session 4).

5. Past as PROCESS (modern societies)

Modern people like change ("new" = "better"). The past still matters, now as the **story of how we got here** (development, progress).

Paradox: **the more things change, the more we need history** to understand change.

e.g. People accept new technology (phones, bicycles) easily but resist social change (family, morals).

6. Genealogy (finding ancestors)

New groups want **heroic ancestors** to look legitimate.

e.g. Revolutionaries claiming Spartacus as an ancestor; schoolbooks teaching national heroes like Joan of Arc.

What history CAN do (*On History*)

Show where today's institutions came from; separate what is really new from what is old; expose invented traditions. It **explains how the present was made**.

vs

What history CANNOT do

Predict the future exactly; give ready-made lessons or a political programme. "History ceases to be of use at the very moment when we need it most."

Hobsbawm · *Past & Present*, 1972 | Zapata (Mexico) | Warsaw = symbolic restoration | "myth of vulgar social science"

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Explain Hobsbawm's idea of the past as pattern, model and process.

Hobsbawm (1972) argues that "the past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness": every society uses its past, but in different ways depending on how fast it changes.

In **traditional societies** the past is a **pattern**: people copy inherited customs. Yet these societies are not static. Change is quietly absorbed, as when nomads treated lorries as just another form of their camel trade.

When change speeds up, the past becomes a **model**, chosen on purpose. Calls for "restoration" show that continuity has already broken. Zapata's peasants tried to restore their old lands but ended up making a revolution. Restoration can be effective or only **symbolic**, like rebuilding Warsaw after WWII.

In **modern societies** the past becomes a **process**, the story of progress that explains the present.

But the past is often selected or even invented for present needs, as in nationalism. History cannot predict the future, but it helps us understand how the present was made.

SESSION 2

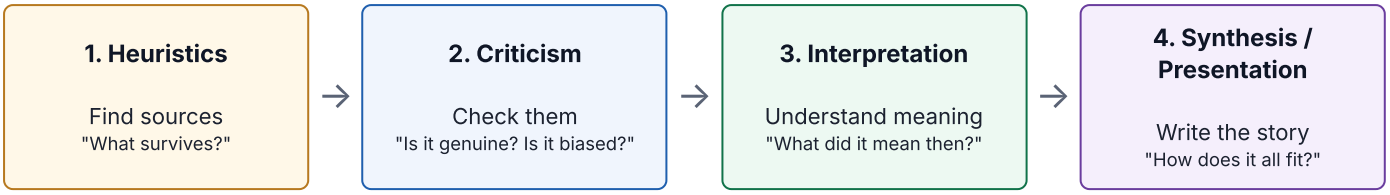
Historical Methods & Sources

Matthew Lange, *Comparative-Historical Methods* (2013), ch. 1 · Charlotte Backerra, "Source criticism for cultural history" (2024)

IN ONE LINE

Historians work like detectives: they collect sources, check whether they can be trusted, interpret what they mean, and explain why things happened, often by comparing cases.

Picture it: how a historian works



These are **Droysen's 4 steps** (1868): heuristic → source analysis → interpretation → presentation.

Key ideas

Source vs evidence

A **source** is anything left from the past. It becomes **evidence** only when a historian uses it, after checking it, to answer a question.

e.g. An old coin is a source; when you use it to prove that a king ruled in 300 CE, it becomes evidence.

Primary / secondary / tertiary

Primary = made at the time. **Secondary** = later analysis. **Tertiary** = summaries.

e.g. Primary: Xuanzang's travel diary, an inscription. Secondary: a historian's book about Xuanzang. Tertiary: an encyclopedia entry.

Source criticism

External: is it genuine (paper, ink, handwriting)?
Internal: who wrote it, for whom, when, why?

e.g. James Mill (S4) never visited India and trusted hostile reports, which is a failure of source criticism.

Common mistakes to avoid

Anachronism = judging the past by today's ideas.
Whig history / teleology = telling the past as a straight march towards today.

e.g. Calling an ancient king "anti-democratic" judges him by modern values.

Lange: comparative-historical analysis (CHA) MUST KNOW

What it is: explaining big social changes (revolutions, states, nationalism, capitalism) by **combining two things**:

Within-case (the "historical")

Look **deep inside one case** over time and trace step by step how A led to B (**process tracing**).

e.g. How exactly did the French monarchy collapse?

+

Comparison (the "comparative")

Look **across several cases** to find what they share and where they differ.

e.g. Compare the French, Russian and Chinese revolutions.

Its 4 defining elements

1. Within-case methods
2. Comparative methods
3. Believes real causes **can** be found (social-science outlook)
4. Studies **big units**: states, classes, economies (Tilly: "big structures, large processes, huge comparisons")

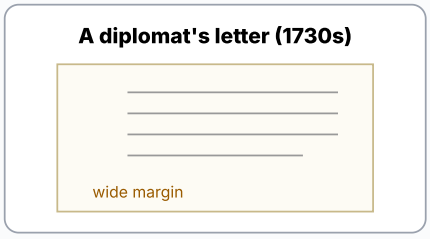
Two kinds of explanation

Ideographic = explains **one unique** case.
Nomothetic = finds **general laws** for many cases.
CHA sits **in between**.

e.g. Bendix (*Kings or People*): every country's path was unique (ideographic). Skocpol: revolutions happen when the state breaks down **and** peasants can rise up (more general).

Backerra: source criticism for cultural history MUST KNOW

Argument: the basic method (Ranke and Droysen) is about 150 years old and still works. But **cultural historians ask new questions**: not just "what happened?" but **"what did it mean?"** They read **symbols, ceremony, language, space and emotions**. The last step, **presentation**, is still not thought about enough.



Old (political) question:
"Who said what to whom, and when?"

New (cultural) questions:
- Wider margin = higher-ranking reader (hierarchy)
- Italian / French / Latin chosen to show status
- Complaining of "cold" = negotiations were frozen

Backerra's example: the same letter answers different questions depending on what you ask.

Droysen 4 steps (1868) | **Ranke**: archives, source criticism | **Lange**: CHA | **Backerra**: cultural history | Skocpol / Bendix

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. "Lange shows how historians explain; Backerra shows how they know." Discuss.

Historical method is both a science of evidence and an art of interpretation, and the two readings cover each side.

Lange explains how historians build **causal explanations** through comparative-historical analysis. It combines deep within-case study (process tracing) with comparison across cases, and focuses on big units like states and classes. For example, Skocpol compared revolutions and found they needed both a weak state and peasants able to revolt. CHA sits between unique (ideographic) and general (nomothetic) explanation.

Backerra explains how historians decide whether evidence can be **trusted**, through source criticism (Droysen's heuristic, analysis, interpretation, presentation). She shows that cultural historians use the same method but ask new questions about meaning: in diplomatic letters, wide margins showed rank, and the choice of language showed status.

But both have limits. Comparison can over-generalise, and presentation is still neglected. Together they form the full workflow: find sources → check them → compare → explain.

SESSION 3

Global vs Regional History (Scale)

Thomas Hall (ed.), *Comparing Globalizations*, chs. 1 & 8 + Lecture 3

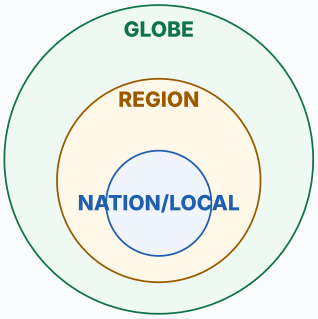
IN ONE LINE

Global history asks how places are connected; regional history asks how a place works inside. Good history uses both, because the scale you choose changes the story.

Picture it: zooming in and out

Global history
- connections, trade, movement
- risk: too abstract

e.g. the world economy



Regional history
- depth, local life, diversity
- risk: too isolated

e.g. Bengal, Gujarat

The same event looks different at each ring. No single scale is enough.

Key ideas

Wallerstein's "world-system"

From the 1500s the world economy became one system with a **core** (rich, skilled production), a **semi-periphery** and a **periphery** (raw materials, cheap labour).

"A world-system is not the system of the world": it is a system that is **a world in itself**, often smaller than the whole globe.

e.g. Europe as core, colonies as periphery. (He put South Asia in the semi-periphery; critics like Bayly called this Eurocentric.)

Hall: MULTIPLE globalizations

There was **not one** globalization that began recently. There were **many**, with **deep histories** going back thousands of years.

Why care? "How can one tell what is new if one does not know what is old?"

e.g. Trade across the Indian Ocean (S7) was a globalization 1,000 years before the internet.

The big debate: one system or many?

Frank: ONE world system growing for 5,000 years. **Chase-Dunn & Hall**: MANY world-systems at different times and places.

Think of it like: One family tree vs many separate families that sometimes intermarry.

Comparison depends on purpose

You can compare apples and oranges **if you are talking about fruit**. What you compare depends on your question.

e.g. Compare the British and American empires to ask whether America is "exceptional" (Julian Go says it is not).

Nation borders mislead (Hall ch. 8)

"India", "China" or "Bangladesh" did not exist in their modern form in the past. So think in **nation, region and globe**.

e.g. Bengal's history spans today's India and Bangladesh (S8).

Why India is the perfect test case

India has **many regions inside it** and **links outside** (Africa, Arabia, Southeast Asia). The Indian Ocean is where regional and global meet.

Example to memorise: Vasco da Gama (1498) at 3 scales

Scale	How his arrival at Calicut looks
National	The start of Europeans in India, which later led to colonial rule
Regional	Just a **new player** in an ocean already full of Gujarati, Arab and Chetti merchants (a Gujarati pilot even guided him)
Global	A new sea route around Africa (the Cape) that bypassed the old Red Sea and Venetian route

Lesson: Europe **changed** an already-connected world; it did not **create** connection.

Wallerstein: core/periphery | **Hall**: multiple globalizations | **Frank**: one system | **Chase-Dunn & Hall**: many systems

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Why should global and regional history be read together? Use India as an example.

Global history studies how places are **connected** (trade, migration, empire), while regional history studies how a place **works internally** (local society and culture). Each alone is weak: global history can become too abstract, and regional history too isolated.

Hall argues there were **multiple globalizations** with long histories, not one modern one, and Wallerstein showed how a world-system links a core and a periphery. But such big models need regional detail to test them.

India shows why both are needed. It contains many regions (Gujarat, Bengal, Malabar), yet it was linked to Africa, Arabia and China through the Indian Ocean. Vasco da Gama's arrival in 1498 looks like the start of colonialism at the national scale, but at the regional scale he was only a new player in a crowded ocean.

So history is strongest when it moves across scales: modern nation borders mislead us about the past, and we must ask both "how was it connected?" and "how did it work inside?"

SESSION 4

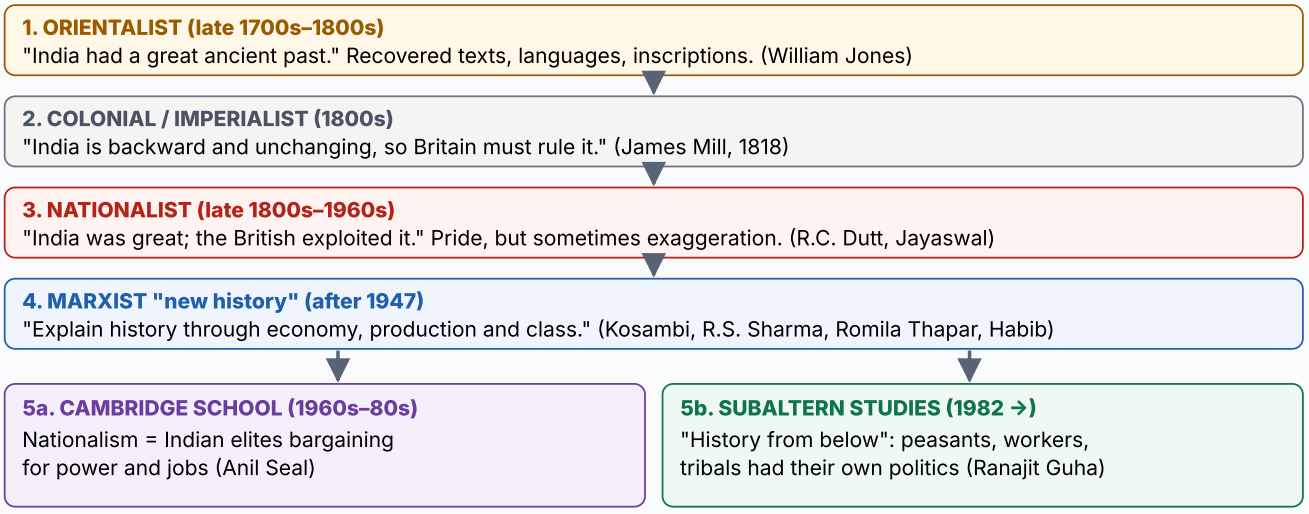
Indian Schools of Historical Thought

E. Sreedharan, *A Textbook of Historiography*, chs. 14–16 + Lecture 4 (Said, Cambridge School). **Very likely essay topic.**

IN ONE LINE

Indian history has been written by different groups, each answering the one before: Orientalists recovered ancient India, colonial writers called it backward, nationalists defended it, Marxists looked at economy and class, and Subaltern historians looked at ordinary people.

Picture it: the chain of schools (learn this order)



Each school reacted to the one above it. The Cambridge School and the Subaltern school both challenged nationalist history, from opposite sides.

1. Orientalists (Indology) MUST KNOW

Problem they solved: the British thought ancient India had "no history" (no proper written history books). So history had to be rebuilt from **texts, languages, inscriptions, coins and ruins**.

What they achieved

- **William Jones** founded the **Asiatic Society of Bengal (1784)**.
- He found that Sanskrit is related to Greek, Latin and English (the **Indo-European** language family).
- He matched the Greek "Sandrocottas" with **Chandragupta Maurya**, giving the first firm date, **325 BC** (the **"sheet anchor"** of Indian chronology).
- **Prinsep** read the **Brahmi script** of Ashoka's inscriptions (1834); **Cunningham** started archaeology (ASI).

The problems

- From "shared language" they jumped to a shared **"Aryan race"**, which was later used to justify British (white) superiority and an Aryan–Dravidian divide.
- Exaggeration ("Sanskrit more perfect than Greek").
- **Edward Said (*Orientalism*, 1978):** this knowledge was also **power**. It helped Britain classify and rule India.

e.g. Translating Hindu law books helped British courts govern Indians; Jones himself was a judge.

2. Colonial / imperialist history MUST KNOW

James Mill, *History of British India* (1818)

He **never visited India**, knew no Indian language, and used only hostile sources. He called Hindu society one of the "rudest" states of mind.

He split history into **Hindu, Muslim and British periods** (still used today). His book was the textbook for British officers at **Haileybury College**.

e.g. A perfect example of bad source criticism (S2).

The colonial "story" in 3 myths

1. **Static India**: it never changed.
2. **Oriental despotism**: cruel kings and powerless villages.
3. So **Britain brings progress**, which justifies colonial rule.

Others: Elphinstone (fairer, "Tacitus of India"), Elliot & Dowson (attacked Muslim rule), Vincent Smith (textbook writer).

3. Nationalist history MUST KNOW

What they did (strengths)

- Defended Indian civilisation and showed a "golden age".
- **K.P. Jayaswal**, *Hindu Polity* (1918): ancient India had **republics**, not just despots.
- **R.C. Dutt** and **Naoroji**: the **drain of wealth** to Britain, which began economic history.
- Started regional history (e.g. south India by Nilakanta Sastri).

but

Problems (weaknesses)

- **Exaggeration and chauvinism**: e.g. claims of aeroplanes in the epics.
- Used sources "like a lawyer trying to win a case" (Basham on Jayaswal).
- Thapar: glorified the past as "compensation for a humiliating present".
- Hindu-centred, which fed **communal** history.

4. Marxist "new history" MUST KNOW

Big idea: not new sources, but **new questions** about the old ones: **Who produced what? Who owned land? Who worked for whom?**

D.D. Kosambi (the founder)

History = "successive developments in the **means and relations of production**", i.e. tools, and who controls work.

e.g. The iron plough cleared forests, tribes broke up, and **caste** grew as a new way to organise farm labour.

R.S. Sharma · Romila Thapar · Irfan Habib

Sharma: "Indian **feudalism**" (land grants to Brahmins and officials, declining towns). **Thapar**: Ashoka's *dhamma* was a social and political policy; no massive "Aryan invasion". **Habib**: Mughal peasants were crushed by the land-revenue demand.

Why it was an advance

From kings and battles to **ordinary people**, the economy and society; used archaeology and other disciplines; destroyed the "static India" and "Aryan race" myths.

but

Criticism

Class can become a "**master explanation**" for everything, ignoring religion, culture and ideas; heavy jargon; Marxists themselves disagreed.

5. Cambridge School vs Subaltern Studies MUST KNOW

Cambridge School (Anil Seal, Gallagher)

The freedom movement was mainly **Indian elites competing** for power, jobs and patronage, through local politics and factions.

e.g. Critics: this ignores ideals and mass anger against British rule.

vs

Subaltern Studies (Ranajit Guha, 1982)

"Subaltern" (from **Gramsci**) = people of low rank. Peasants, workers and tribals had their **own politics**; they were not just followers of leaders.

e.g. Peasant revolts in Awadh; how peasants saw Gandhi as a miracle-worker (Shahid Amin).

Guha's point: both colonial and nationalist history are "**elitist**". One says the British made India; the other says Indian leaders freed it. Neither gives credit to ordinary people.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS: THE PROFESSOR'S ESSAY (15 MARKS)

Q. Was the shift from colonial and nationalist history to Marxist "new history" a major advance?

Intro: Each school of Indian history reflected the politics of its time (Hobsbawm: the past is used for present needs).

Colonial history (James Mill, 1818) described India as static and despotic to justify British rule, and used biased sources. **Nationalist history** (Jayaswal's republics, Dutt's drain of wealth) answered with pride and opened economic history, but often exaggerated and glorified a "golden age".

Marxist history was an advance because it asked new questions of old sources: production, land and class (Kosambi on the plough and caste; Sharma on feudalism; Thapar on Ashoka). It moved history from kings to ordinary people and used archaeology and other disciplines.

But it could make class a rigid master key, ignoring culture and religion. The Cambridge School stressed elite politics, and Subaltern Studies (Guha) argued that even Marxists missed peasants' own politics.

Conclusion: it was a real advance in method and scope, but not the final word. History keeps being rewritten.

SESSION 6

India through the Eyes of Foreign Travellers

Tansen Sen, "The Travel Records of Chinese Pilgrims Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing" (2006) · M.S. Khan, "A Twelfth Century Arab Account of Indian Religions" (on al-Shahrastani, 1983)

IN ONE LINE

Foreign travellers fill gaps where Indian records are missing, but every travel account is part evidence, part opinion, so historians must check it against other sources.

Picture it: what goes into a travel account

Observation — what they saw

+

Memory — written years later

+

Interpretation — seen through their religion and culture

+

Opinion — judgements of people

=

Travel writing — useful but biased

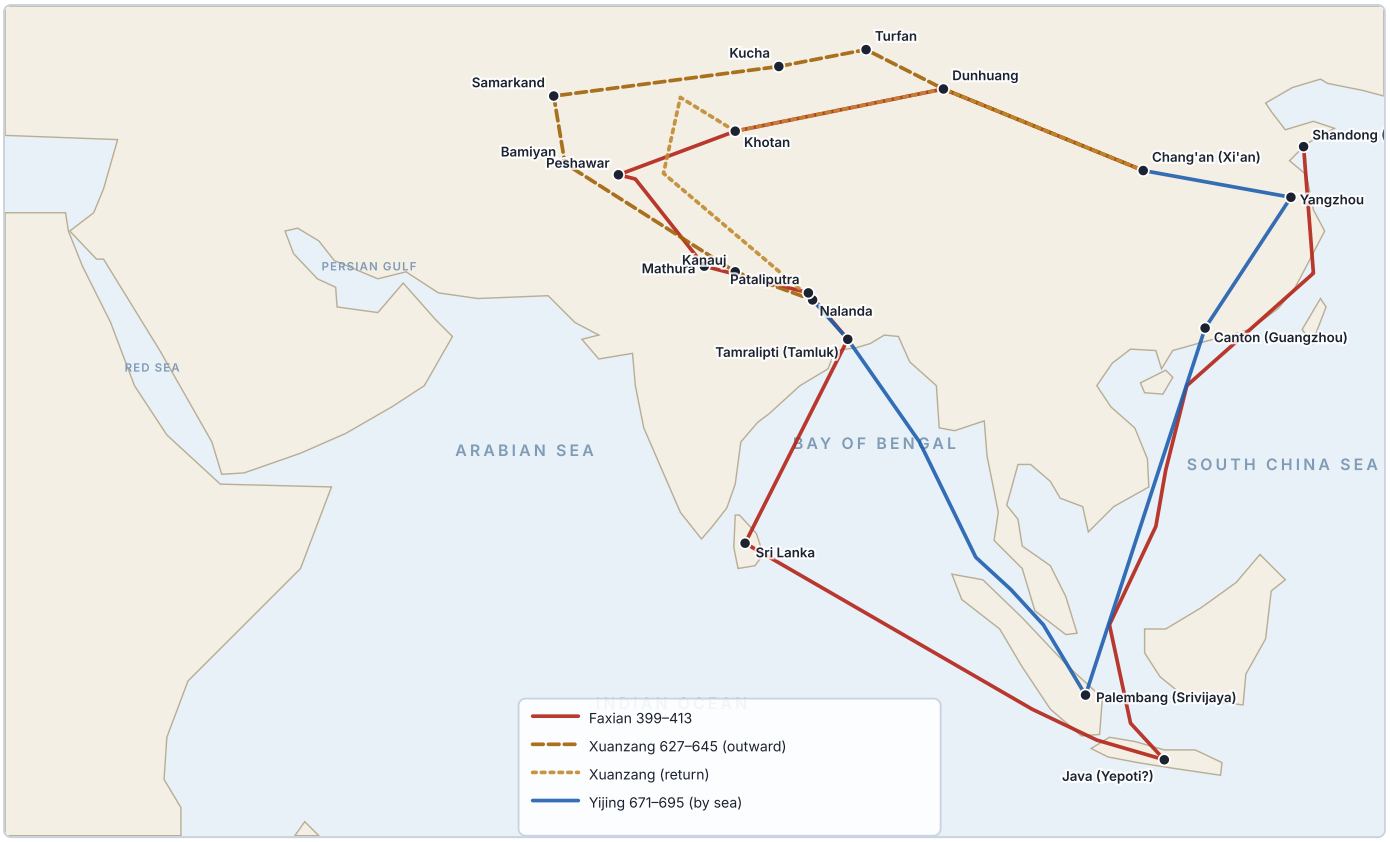
Why useful

- **Eyewitness** accounts
- Notice everyday things locals ignored (food, dress, cities)
- Compare India with their own country
- Fill gaps where Indian records are missing

but

Why careful

- **Language** barriers
- **Religious bias** (Buddhist monks saw everything through Buddhism)
- Saw only **part** of India
- Exaggeration and hearsay



Routes of the three Chinese pilgrims (approximate). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

The three Chinese monks MUST KNOW

Why they came: to collect **Buddhist texts**, visit places linked to the Buddha, and learn from Indian teachers.

Monk	When / route	Remember
Faxian	399–413 · overland there, **by sea** back	Came for **Vinaya** texts (monastery rules). Described **Gupta** India. Returned via **Sri Lanka** on a merchant ship, a scary voyage. Showed that **monks and merchants helped each other**.
Xuanzang	629–645 · overland	"The greatest traveller". Took back **657 texts**. Met King **Harsha** at **Kanauj**; studied at **Nalanda**. Gave India the Chinese name "Yindu". Was also a **diplomat** for the Tang emperor. His notes help archaeologists today.
Yijing	671–695 · **by sea**	Studied at **Srivijaya** (Sumatra) on the way. Recorded daily **monastery rules**. Wrote short lives of **56 Chinese monks** who went to India.

"Borderland complex"

Chinese monks felt China was on the **edge** of the Buddhist world, far from the Buddha's land. Some even wished not to be reborn in China.

e.g. Faxian's companion stayed in India for good.

Their big impact

They made China see India as a **civilised, holy land** (high praise, since the Chinese usually called foreigners "barbarians"). They also show **monks travelling with merchants**, an early sign of trade and religion moving together (Sessions 7–9).

The Arab scholar: al-Shahrastani (12th c.) MUST KNOW

Book: *Kitab al-Milal wa'l-Nihal* ("Book of Religions and Sects"), a chapter on Indian religions. **M.S. Khan** evaluates it.

Strengths

- **Systematic**: neatly classified Indian religions
- **Fair tone**: did not insult Indian religions
- Unique details on **Buddhism**
- Understood that Hindus believe God himself comes down (**avatar**) instead of sending a prophet with a book

but

Weaknesses

- **Never visited India**; knew **no Sanskrit**
- Copied older Arabic books (**secondary** sources)
- Errors: thought "Brahma" was a man's name; treated Buddhism as a branch of Hinduism
- Left out the **Vedas** and **Jainism**; judged India through Islamic ideas

Al-Biruni vs al-Shahrastani (easy comparison)

	Al-Biruni (973–1048)	Al-Shahrastani (1086–1153)
Visited India?	Yes	No
Knew Sanskrit?	Yes	No
Sources	Original Indian texts (**primary**)	Arabic books (**secondary**)
Style	Critical scholar	Compiler

CLEVER POINT FOR ANSWERS

Al-Shahrastani is **poor evidence for what India was really like**, but **good evidence for what 12th-century Muslims believed about India**. The value of a source depends on the question you ask (Backerra, S2).

Faxian 399–413 | **Xuanzang**: Harsha, Nalanda, 657 texts | **Yijing**: Srivijaya, 56 monks

al-Shahrastani: never visited | **al-Biruni**: knew Sanskrit | Megasthenes (Greek, Chandragupta's court)

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. How useful are foreign travellers' accounts as sources for Indian history?

Where Indian records are scarce, foreign accounts are very useful, but travel writing mixes **observation, memory, interpretation and opinion**, so it is both evidence and interpretation.

The Chinese monks were **eyewitnesses**. Faxian described Gupta India and his sea voyage home; Xuanzang described Harsha's Kanauj and Nalanda and brought back 657 texts; Yijing recorded monastery life and studied at Srivijaya. They also show monks travelling with merchants. **But** they saw India through a Buddhist lens.

Al-Shahrastani systematically classified Indian religions, **but** he never visited India, knew no Sanskrit, relied on older Arabic books and made errors (e.g. "Brahma" as a man). Al-Biruni, who learned Sanskrit and used original texts, is more reliable.

So historians must **corroborate** these accounts with inscriptions, coins and archaeology. Used critically, they also show that India was **connected** to Asia, not isolated.

SESSION 7

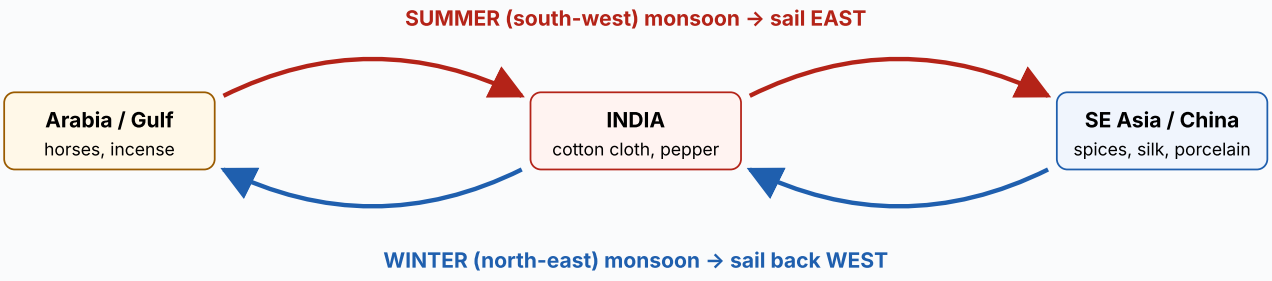
Baghdad to Canton: Trade in the Medieval Indian Ocean

William Bernstein, *A Splendid Exchange*, ch. 4 (2008) + Lecture 7

IN ONE LINE

Long before Europeans came, the Indian Ocean was a busy "premodern globalisation" from East Africa to China, run by the monsoon winds, merchants and shared rules, with India at the centre.

Picture it: the monsoon "timetable"



Winds reverse each season, so merchants sailed in segments (stages). Goods from Baghdad to Canton usually changed ships at least 3 times, often in India.

Key ideas

A "system", not random trips

Trade was **regular and lasting**. It moved **goods** (cotton, pepper, silk, horses, porcelain), **people** (merchants, pilgrims, judges), **ideas** (Islam, law) and **institutions** (taxes, credit, contracts).

e.g. A Gujarati merchant sails to Malacca with cloth, swaps it for spices and porcelain, and returns on the next monsoon.

Islam as "trade infrastructure"

From Cairo to Malacca, Muslim merchants followed the **same law and customs**, which built trust at a distance. The hajj connected the whole network.

e.g. Customs duty: Muslims 2.5%, Christians and Jews 5%, others 10%. Southeast Asia became Muslim through **merchants who married locally**, not through armies.

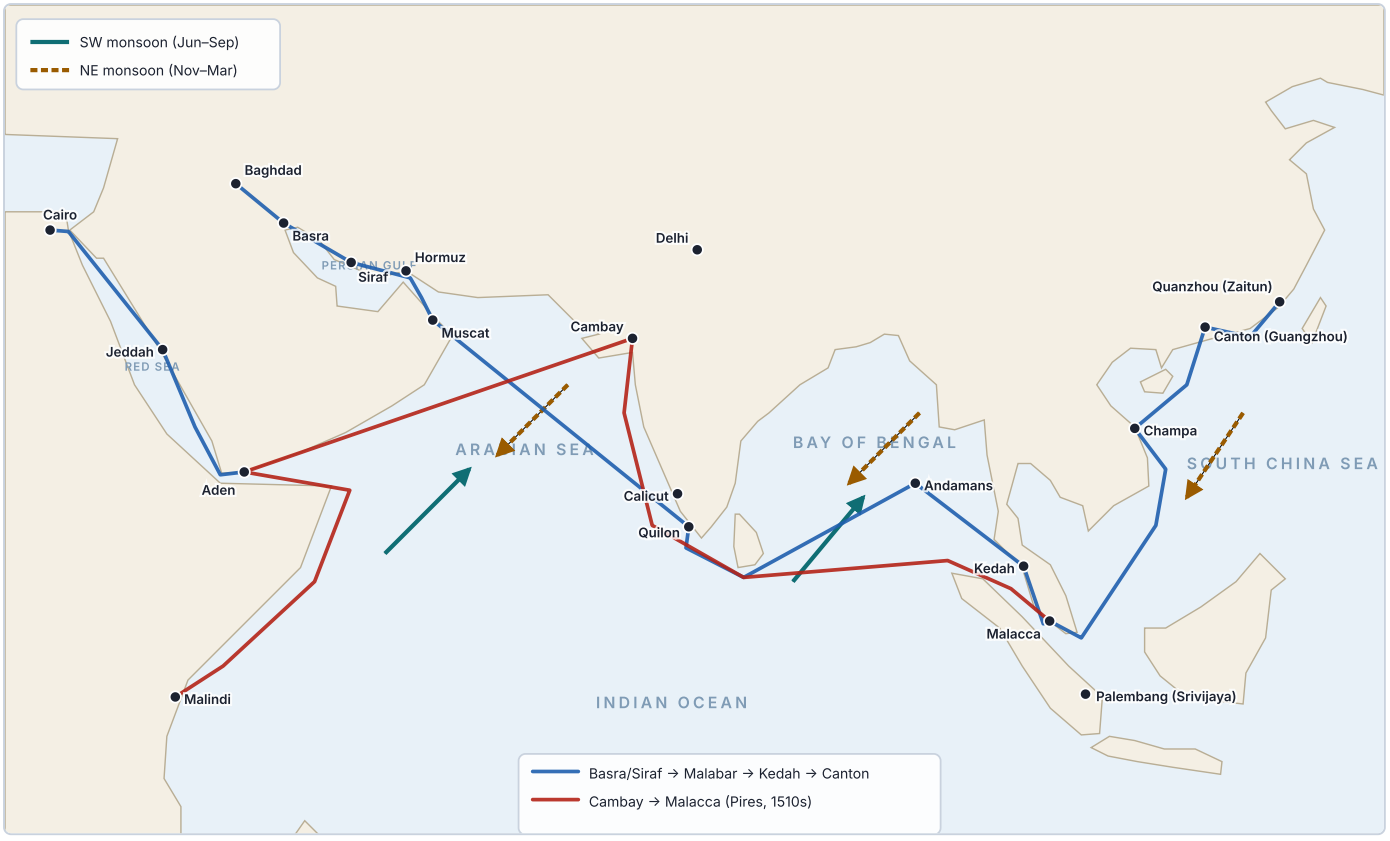
Why India was central (not just geography)

1. **Middle-man**: ships from the west and east met at Indian ports
2. **Producer**: cotton cloth ("if spices were glamorous, cloth was indispensable") and Malabar **pepper**
3. **Gujarat / Cambay**: expert merchants (even the Portuguese Tomé Pires praised them)
4. **Cultural carrier**: Indian Muslim traders spread Islam east

Malacca: success through good rules

Founded c.1400 by **Parameswara**. **Low taxes, honest courts, transparent prices** drew traders; Pires counted **84 languages** spoken there.

Think of it like: Asia's Singapore of the 1400s: success came from good institutions, not only location.



The Baghdad–Canton sea route (Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind, 9th c.) and the later Cambay–Malacca axis (Pires). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

The story in 4 quick stages

Stage	What happened (just remember the bold)
1. 7th–9th c.	**Tang China + Abbasid Baghdad (750)**: direct sea trade Basra → India → Canton. In **878 Huang Chao**'s rebels massacred foreign merchants at Canton.
2. 13th–14th c.	**Mongol** period. **Ibn Battuta** (Moroccan judge) worked in **Delhi** under Muhammad bin Tughluq; he travelled the whole Muslim world.
3. 1405–1433	**Zheng He**'s huge Chinese fleets (7 voyages) reached India and Africa, then China **stopped** sea voyages.
4. c.1500	**Malacca** at its height (Tomé Pires) → captured by the **Portuguese in 1511**.

SOURCES: EACH ONE HAS ITS OWN ANGLE (SOURCE CRITICISM AGAIN)

Akhbar al-Sin wa'l-Hind (c.851, Arab merchants): route details. · **Marvels of India** (10th c.): mixes real sailing life with fantasy. · **Marco Polo**: accurate but likes marvels. · **Ibn Battuta**: a Muslim judge, little interest in trade. · **Tomé Pires** (1511): precise numbers, admired Asian trade.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. Why was India central to the Indian Ocean trading system before 1500?

Bernstein shows that the medieval Indian Ocean was a form of **premodern globalisation**, a regular system linking East Africa, Arabia, India, Southeast Asia and China. India was at its centre.

First, because of the **monsoon**, voyages were done in segments, and ships from the west and east met at Indian ports. India was the **middle-man**, where goods were sorted, taxed and re-shipped. Second, India was a major **producer**: cotton textiles bought across Asia, and Malabar pepper. Third, **Gujarati** merchants of Cambay were so skilled that the Portuguese Tomé Pires told his countrymen to learn from them. Fourth, Indian Muslim traders spread **Islam** to Southeast Asia through trade and marriage.

But geography alone does not explain it: good ports, fair taxes and shared Islamic commercial law mattered too (as at Malacca).

So Europe entered an **already-connected world**; it did not create it.

SESSION
8

Silk Route Connections I: Two Lenses on the Silk Road

Valerie Hansen, *The Silk Road*, ch. 5 (Chang'an) · Jayati Bhattacharya, "Old Routes, New Dreams" (2021, Bengal–China) + Lecture 8

IN ONE LINE

There was no single "Silk Road" but many routes. Hansen looks through a city (Chang'an); Bhattacharya looks through a region (Bengal). The lens you pick decides which Silk Road you see.

START HERE: WHAT IS THE "SILK ROAD"?

The name was invented in **1877** by a German geographer, **Ferdinand von Richthofen**. He drew it as **one line** from China to Europe. In reality it was a **web of many routes**, few people travelled the whole way, and goods passed from hand to hand. Much more than silk moved: **people, religions (Buddhism, Christianity, Zoroastrianism), ideas and many goods**.



Two lenses: Chang'an as terminus (Hansen) and Bengal as circulatory centre (Bhattacharya). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Hansen: the CITY lens

Chang'an (modern Xi'an), capital of the Tang dynasty, was a **cosmopolitan** city of about 1 million people, home to foreigners, monks, merchants and refugees.

Main point: few goods travelled the whole way; **people and ideas** mattered more.

Evidence: archaeology (tombs, hoards, documents).

vs

Bhattacharya: the REGION lens

Bengal was not a "periphery" (edge) but a **hub** linking rivers, mountains and sea to China and Southeast Asia (the **"Southern Silk Road"**).

Main point: centres and peripheries are **made by politics**, not by nature.

Evidence: trade goods like **cotton** and **cowrie shells**.

Hansen: Chang'an (key examples)

Sogdians (Central Asian traders)

Merchants from **Samarkand** who settled in China. Their leaders, called ***sabao***, were headmen of foreign communities.

e.g. The tomb of **An Jia** (d. 579) is Chinese in shape but has a **Zoroastrian** fire altar: **mixing of cultures** ("hybridity").

Hejiacun hoard (treasure found in 1970)

Over 1,000 items, but only a **few imported** ones; most were made **in China** by migrant craftsmen.

e.g. This proves Hansen's point: **skills and people** travelled more than goods. Fewer than 50 Roman coins have been found in all of China.

Rise and fall

Chang'an grew under the **Tang**, then suffered: the **An Lushan rebellion (755)**, followed by attacks on Sogdians; foreign religions banned (843–845); rebels burned the city. Trade shifted to the **sea**.

Everyday life too

Pawnshop tickets show ordinary people (a quarter of them women) pawning clothes, not grand luxury trade.

Bhattacharya: Bengal (key examples)

Cotton, not just silk ("Cotton Road")

Bengal's fine **cotton cloth (muslin)** was sold to China for centuries.

e.g. So why do we say "Silk Road" and not "Cotton Road"? Because Bengal was later imagined as a "periphery".

Cowrie shells (money)

Small shells used as **cheap money** from the Maldives through Bengal to Yunnan in China. Where cowries spread shows how far the Southern Silk Road reached.

e.g. Faxian, Xuanzang and Ibn Battuta mention them; in Bengal a chicken cost about 448 cowries.

Colonial rule changed the routes

The British **restructured** trade (railways, tea, new borders). Then **1947** (Partition) and the **1962** India–China war **closed** old routes, and Bengal became a "border" zone.

Today: old routes, new politics

China's **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI, 2013)** and India's **Act East Policy (2014)** both **use the memory** of old routes, but **selectively**, for their own goals.

e.g. This is Hobsbawm's "use of the past" (S1) in action.

BIG LESSONS (USE IN ANY SILK ROAD ANSWER)

1. **No single road**: many routes, by land, river and sea.
2. **Scale matters**: a city view and a regional view show different things (S3).
3. **Centres and peripheries are made**: Bengal was called "peripheral" only from Delhi's or London's point of view.
4. **Connectivity changes over time**: it grows, shrinks, reroutes and gets "revived" for politics.

Richthofen 1877 "Silk Road" · **Hansen**: Chang'an, Sogdians · **Bhattacharya**: Bengal hub · BRI 2013 · Act East 2014 · An Lushan 755

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. "There is no single Silk Road." Discuss with reference to Hansen and Bhattacharya.

The term "Silk Road" was coined by Richthofen in 1877 as one line from China to Europe, but the readings show a **web of routes** carrying people, religions and many goods.

Hansen uses a **city lens**. Through archaeology in Chang'an (the Sogdian tomb of An Jia, the Hejiacun hoard) she shows a cosmopolitan city where foreigners mixed cultures, but where **few goods** travelled long distances. People, skills and ideas mattered more. The city declined after the An Lushan rebellion, and trade moved to the sea.

Bhattacharya uses a **regional lens**. Bengal was a **hub** linking rivers, mountains and sea, with trade in cotton and cowrie shells reaching Yunnan. It was later made "peripheral" by colonial borders, Partition and the 1962 war.

Today, China's BRI and India's Act East use the Silk Road memory selectively, a political use of the past. So the Silk Road was **multiple and changing**, and what we see depends on our lens.

SESSION 9

Silk Route Connections II: Buddhism Across the Sea

Tansen Sen, "Buddhism and the Maritime Crossings" (2014) + Lecture 9

IN ONE LINE

Buddhism also travelled from India to China by sea, carried by monks on merchant ships. Trade and religion helped each other, and Sri Lanka and Srivijaya became key Buddhist centres on the way.

Key idea 1: why "Maritime Silk Road" is a misleading name

Sen's 3 objections

1. **Silk was not the main cargo** at sea. It was beads, pearls and precious stones, and later incense, pepper, spices and porcelain.
2. It makes **China** look like the centre, but Indian, Southeast Asian and Arab ships mattered just as much. China became active at sea only from the **10th century**.
3. It **ignores Southeast Asia**, whose sailors had linked the seas since about 2500 BCE.

Sen's alternative

See maritime Asia as a **multi-centred** world (many centres), not a "Chinese road".

And stop arguing over whether Buddhism reached China first by land or by sea: the evidence shows **both**. Land and sea **complemented** each other.

Key idea 2: monks + merchants



e.g. the "seven jewels" (saptaratna) offered to monasteries created demand for pearls and coral

Lecture: religion did not just "go along with" trade; it became part of trade itself.

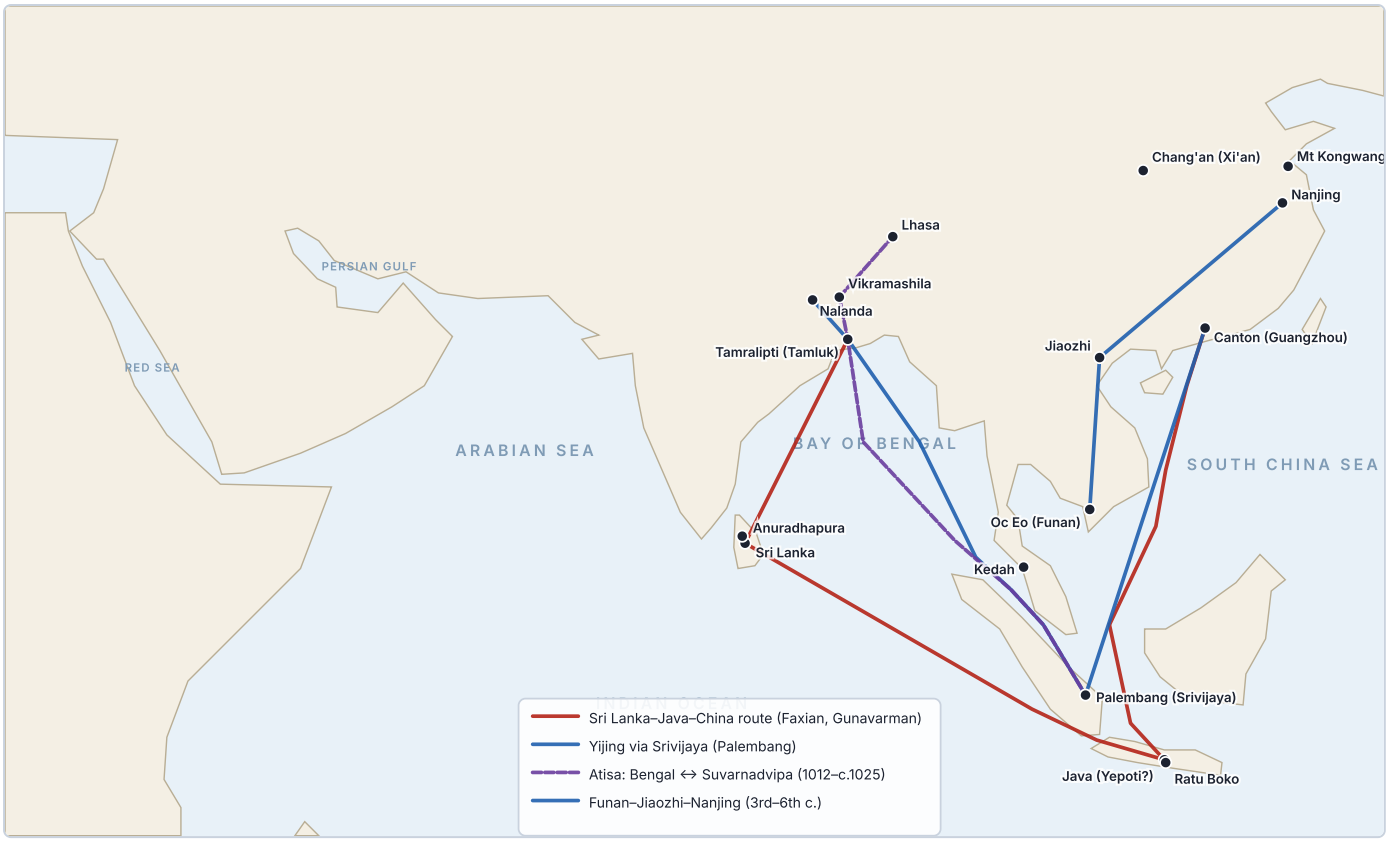
Example: the ship-owner Nandin (5th c.)

An Indian ship-owner who carried the monk **Gunavarman** and groups of **Sri Lankan nuns** to China, and helped translate texts.

But not always friendly

Sen adds that some merchants were **hostile**.

e.g. In a storm (411), "Brahmin" merchants on **Faxian**'s ship wanted to throw him off as bad luck. His patron saved him.



Maritime Buddhist networks (Tansen Sen). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Key idea 3: Southeast Asia was first just a "transit zone"

1st–4th c.

Just a
stop-over
: ships changed crews and took supplies. No monasteries yet.

→

5th c.

First Buddhist inscription, by the sea captain
Buddhagupta
(Kedah, Malaysia)

→

7th–13th c.

Srivijaya
(Sumatra) becomes a big
Buddhist learning centre

Think of it like: A flight stop-over: Buddhism flew "direct" from India to China (**long-distance** transmission, Zürcher's idea). The places in between only became Buddhist later.

Key idea 4: Srivijaya and Sri Lanka as hubs

Srivijaya (Palembang, Sumatra)

- **Yijing**: over **1,000 monks** there; Chinese monks should study there **1–2 years** before going to India.
- **Atisa**, an Indian monk, went there to learn (1012), then went to **Tibet**: knowledge flowed **back to India** too.
- Its kings gave gifts to **Nalanda** and **Nagapattinam** (S10).

&

Sri Lanka

- Not just the home of Theravada: also **Tantric** Buddhism and **relics**.
- Kings wanted its relics for power: **Kublai Khan** sent an envoy (1284); **Zheng He** (1410) probably wanted the **tooth relic**.
- Its monastery design was copied in **Java** (the Ratu Boko inscription, 792), **adapted** locally.

Strengths of Sen's article

Connected history, not separate national ones; the **sea as an active space**; uses many kinds of evidence (archaeology, inscriptions, texts); **land and sea** seen as complementary.

but

Limitations (lecture)

Relies heavily on **Chinese texts**; Southeast Asians appear only as middle-men, with **little local agency**; treats all merchants as one group; **women are almost absent**.

OLD VS NEW VIEW OF THE SILK ROADS (LECTURE TABLE, IN SHORT)

Old: one road, over land, luxury goods, China–Europe, centred on states and empires. → **New:** many roads, land **and** sea, people and ideas too, many centres, networks.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (10 MARKS)

Q. How did trade and religion support each other in the maritime spread of Buddhism? (Sen)

Tansen Sen argues that Buddhism reached China by sea as well as by land, and that this spread was **closely tied to trade**. He also rejects the label "maritime Silk Road", because silk was not the main cargo and the label makes China the centre.

Merchants gave monks **passage** on ships, funded monasteries and carried relics and texts. Monasteries gave merchants lodging, trust and blessings, and Buddhist rituals such as offering the "seven jewels" created **demand** for pearls and coral. The ship-owner Nandin, who carried Gunavarman and Sri Lankan nuns to China, shows this link. **But** relations were not always friendly: merchants on Faxian's ship wanted to abandon him in a storm.

At first Southeast Asia was only a **transit zone**. Later **Srivijaya** (where Yijing found 1,000 monks) and **Sri Lanka** (relics and Tantric teaching) became hubs, and knowledge even flowed back to India (Atisa).

Limitation: Sen relies mainly on Chinese sources. Still, he shows that religion became part of trade itself.

SESSION 10

Religions in India: Encounters, Adaptations, Travels

T.N. Madan, *India's Religions* (Introduction) · John Guy, "Tamil Merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist Diaspora" · H.P. Ray, "A 'Chinese' Pagoda at Nagapattinam" + Lecture 10. **The professor's model short answer comes from here.**

IN ONE LINE

Religion in India is plural, diverse inside, and lived (not just texts). When people travelled across the ocean, religion travelled with them and changed on the way.

Part 1: How to think about religion in India (Madan + lecture)

Plurality ≠ Pluralism

Plurality = a **fact**: many religions exist. **Pluralism** = a **value or practice**: people actively live together with difference.

e.g. A city with a temple, a mosque and a church has plurality. Neighbours attending each other's festivals is pluralism.

Every religion is diverse inside

No religion is one single thing. Madan calls Hinduism a **"federation of faiths"**: no single founder or book.

e.g. Hinduism: Shaiva, Vaishnava, Shakta, bhakti. Islam: Sunni, Shia, Sufi orders. Sikhism: Khalsa and Sahajdhari.

Doctrine vs lived religion

Doctrine = what holy texts and priests say. **Lived religion** = what people actually do: food, festivals, pilgrimage, shrines.

e.g. Texts may draw sharp lines, but Hindus and Muslims both visit **Sufi shrines**; the Mapillas of Kerala kept local customs.

Religion is mixed into society

Religion connects with caste, family, gender, economy and politics.

e.g. A **temple** is also an employer, a bank, a centre of power and a marker of identity.

Dharma is not "religion"

The Western word "religion" means a private belief. **Dharma** means duty, moral order and a whole way of life, covering law, family and society.

Colonial census (from 1871) hardened identities

The British used a **Christian model** of religion (one God, one book, clear membership) and put everyone into **fixed boxes** in the census.

e.g. Fluid identities (e.g. people who were partly Hindu and partly Muslim in practice) became "Hindu **or** Muslim **or** Sikh".

Religions born in India
Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism

+

Religions that came from outside
Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism (Parsis), Bahá'í

Census 1991 (Madan): Hindus about 82%, Muslims about 12%, Christians 2.3%, Sikhs 2%, Buddhists 0.8%, Jains 0.4%. Islam came first through **traders** (Kerala coast), then conquest (Sind 712); it spread mostly **peacefully**, through Sufis and trade.

Did India's plurality produce pluralism? (Madan)

Traditional "pluralism" was a ranking
The Rig Veda says "Truth is one, the wise call it by many names", but traditional Hinduism **tolerated others by ranking them below itself**.

e.g. **Vivekananda**: all religions are true, but Vedanta is the highest. The **Arya Samaj** rejected other religions (exclusivist).

Most pluralist: Gandhi
Gandhi said all religions are **equally true and equally imperfect**, and he refused to rank them. He drew on the Jain idea of ***anekantavada*** (truth has many sides).

e.g. Also **Dara Shikoh** (Mughal prince) called Hinduism and Islam "twin brothers".

TWO KINDS OF PLURALISM (MADAN'S KEY CONCLUSION)

Folk pluralism = ordinary people **naturally** living with difference in everyday life. **Intellectual or secular pluralism** = an **idea** promoted by elites and the state (e.g. *sarva dharma samabhava*, "equal respect for all religions"). Madan says there is a **gap** between the two.

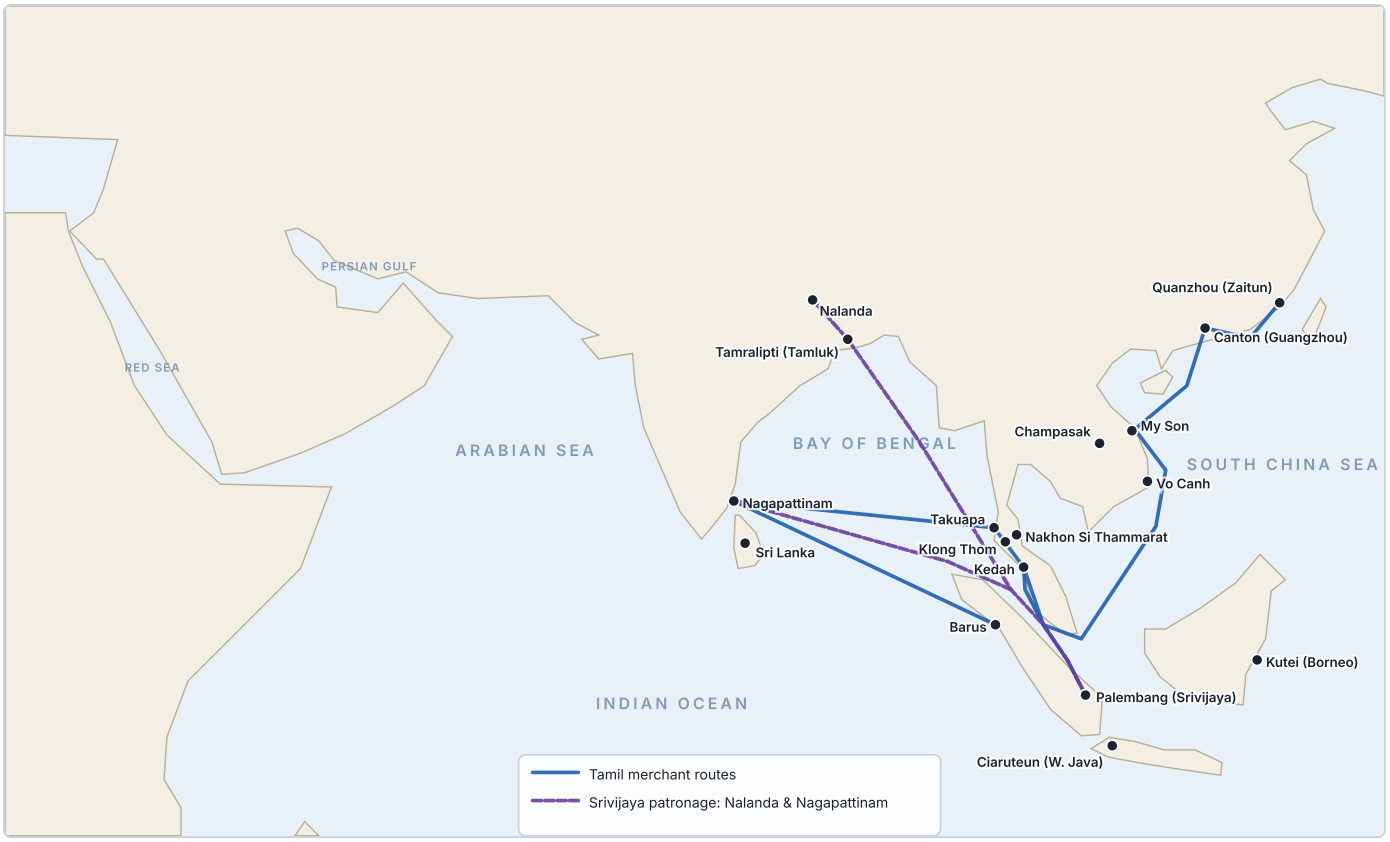
Part 2: Religion on the move (Guy + Ray)

Old view: "diffusion"
India → Southeast Asia, one way. India gives, others copy.

→

New view: "circulation"
India ↔ Sri Lanka ↔ Southeast Asia ↔ China, in many directions, and religion **changes** as it moves.

Who carried religion? Merchants (created the movement) · **Brahmins** (rituals for kings) · **Buddhist monks** (monasteries, teaching) · **Kings** (patronage) · **Artisans** (statues). Pattern: **merchant → settlement → community → temple**.



Inscriptions and sacred sites of the Hindu–Buddhist maritime world (Guy; H.P. Ray). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

John Guy: Tamil merchants carried Hindu and Buddhist culture

Purnavarman (West Java, c.450)

A local king wrote a Sanskrit inscription with **Vishnu's footprints**, which were also **his own**.

e.g. India was not simply copied: he **used** Vishnu to make himself look powerful. Indian ideas + local politics = something new.

Inscriptions mark the trade routes

Kutei (Borneo, 4th c.): the earliest Indian-style inscriptions. **Klong Thom** (Thailand): a goldsmith's stone with the earliest **Tamil** inscription. **Takuapa** (9th c.): a temple tank built by **Tamil merchant guilds**.

Tamils in China

By **750** Guangzhou had **3 monasteries** for Indian Brahmins. In **Quanzhou** (1281) a **Tamil–Chinese** inscription dedicates a **Shiva temple**; its pillars were later reused in a Chinese Buddhist temple.

Merchant guilds

Groups like the **Ainnurruvar** and **Manigramam** traded overseas, had their own guards, and paid for temples.

H.P. Ray: Nagapattinam, one port with many religions

The Buddhist monastery (Cudamanivihara)

Built at Nagapattinam (Tamil coast) by the **king of Srivijaya** (Sumatra) with land given by the **Chola kings** (c.1005). Demolished in **1867**.

e.g. Hundreds of **Buddha bronzes** were found. Some Buddha statues were carried in **temple processions like Hindu gods**, showing religions borrowing from each other.

A multi-religious coast

Nagapattinam also had a **Shiva temple** (which received gifts from Srivijaya and gold from China), later a **Sufi dargah** (Nagore) and a **church** (Velankanni).

e.g. Ray: not "first Buddhism, then Hinduism" but **many religions side by side**. This also challenges the old idea (Cunningham's) that Buddhism died out in India around the 7th–8th century.

THE LECTURE'S OVERARCHING ARGUMENT (MEMORISE)

Indian religions became important across Asia **not because they stayed the same, but because they could be carried, translated and reinterpreted** in new places. **Madan** → religion is social and plural · **Guy** → it travelled through merchant networks · **Ray** → it created multi-religious landscapes.

WRITE IT LIKE THIS: THE PROFESSOR'S SHORT ANSWER (10 MARKS)

Q. Distinguish religion as doctrine from religion as lived practice in India.

The lecture and Madan argue that religion is more than belief: it moves from **belief** → **practice** → **experience** → **social life**. So historians must separate doctrine from lived religion.

Doctrine means the official teachings in sacred texts and from religious authorities, such as the Vedas and Manusmriti, the Quran and sharia, or the Sikh Khalsa code. Doctrine tends to draw **clear boundaries** between religions.

Lived religion is what people actually do: food rules, festivals, pilgrimage, local saints. In practice boundaries are **porous**. Hindus and Muslims visit the same Sufi shrines, the Mapilla Muslims of Kerala kept local customs, and Madan calls this everyday mixing "folk pluralism". A temple is also an economic and social institution.

The difference matters. The colonial census (from 1871), using a text-based Christian model, put people into fixed boxes and **hardened identities**. Studying lived religion shows that Indian religions were plural, mixed and changing, as at Nagapattinam, where Buddha images were worshipped like Hindu gods.

SESSION 11

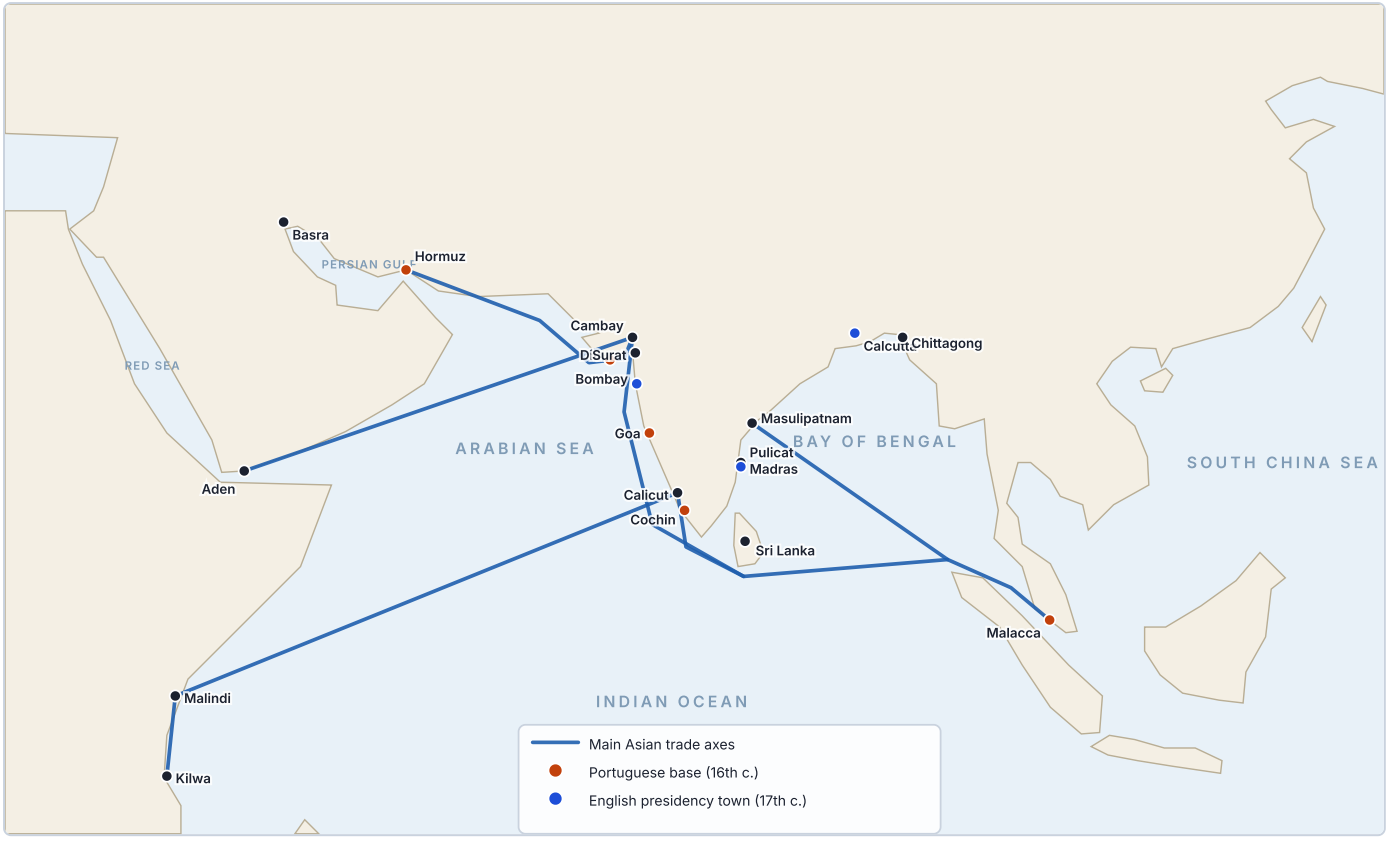
The Indian Ocean as a Connected Space

K.N. Chaudhuri, "Unity and Disunity of Indian Ocean History" (1993) · Tirthankar Roy, "The Indian Ocean Trade, 1500–1800" (2012) + Lecture 11

IN ONE LINE

The Indian Ocean was connected but not the same everywhere ("unity in the large, disunity in the small"). Europeans entered and changed this working system, and trade slowly turned into empire.

"Connected space" means **structured interaction across distance**, not sameness. It works through routes (the monsoon), shared trade customs, migration, religious networks, and even war and diplomacy.



Indian Ocean c.1500–1800: Asian hubs, Portuguese bases, English presidencies (T. Roy). Coastlines simplified; positions approximate.

Chaudhuri: the BIG picture (622–1750) MUST KNOW

UNITY "in the large": one ocean of trade (monsoon, merchants, routes from Suez/Basra to China)
like Braudel's Mediterranean

ISLAM	SANSKRITIC INDIA	SOUTHEAST ASIA	CONFUCIAN CHINA
Middle East	South Asia	islands & mainland	East Asia
bread / wheat	wheat + rice	rice / fish	rice

DISUNITY "in the small": 4 different civilisations, foods, clothes, houses

Chaudhuri: similar at the big level, different at the small level.

Unity in the large, disunity in the small

Two things can look **different up close** but **similar overall** (or the reverse). Word by word, the Rig Veda, the Quran and the Confucian texts differ. But **Arab sailors could sail from Basra to China**, so as a trade system the ocean was one unit.

Think of it like: Different shops in one big market: each sells different things, but it is still one market.

The "ground floor" of daily life barely changed

Food, clothes and houses stayed similar for centuries (**invariance**).

e.g. **Bread zone vs rice zone**; the Muslim pilgrim's white unsewn cloth (*ihram*) has the same ritual meaning as a **Brahmin's** unstitched dress; **dry zones** (brick houses, wheat) vs **wet zones** (bamboo houses, rice, fish ponds).

Time span: 622 to 1750

From the **rise of Islam (622)** and the Tang dynasty (618) to the **Battle of Plassey (1757)**, a whole "life cycle".

Four big expansions shaped it: **Islam, China, Turko-Mongol nomads, and Europe**.

e.g. A critic (Arasaratnam) wrote "750–1750"; Chaudhuri corrected it to 622.

Unity is partly in the historian's mind

Chaudhuri admits that "one Indian Ocean" is a **mental construct**: historians **choose** the unit and period that fit their question.

e.g. "Asia" only makes sense when contrasted with "Europe".

Skip: Chaudhuri's maths and philosophy (set theory, Gödel, Dedekind). At most, write "he used structuralism and set theory".

Roy: trade, companies, empire (1500–1800) MUST KNOW

Before 1500 — Busy Asian trade; India in the middle of the "great arc"

→ **1498 →** — Portuguese: force and passes, but only partial control

→ **1600 →** — English (EIC) and Dutch (VOC) companies

→ **c.1640–1690** — Madras, Bombay, Calcutta port towns

→ **1757–1765** — Plassey, Buxar: trade becomes **empire**

1. A crowded world before Europe

India was the **middle of the "great arc"** of Asian trade, and a producer and market itself: it exported **cotton cloth**, rice and indigo, and imported silver, gold and **horses**.

e.g. Merchants: **Gujarati Muslims** (Cambay), **Mapillas** (Malabar), **Chulias** and **Telugu Chettis** (Coromandel). "Europeans entered a crowded, working world, not an empty stage."

2. The Portuguese: violent but limited

Vasco da Gama reached Calicut in **1498**, guided by a **Gujarati pilot**. Later voyages brought **bombardment** and massacres. They forced ships to buy **passes** (*cartaz*) and held forts (Goa, Hormuz, Malacca).

e.g. But they **never fully controlled** trade and declined after 1640. (Steensgaard: they lived off others' profits instead of making their own.)

3. Companies: power through organisation

English EIC (1600), **Dutch VOC (1602)**, French (1664). What was new: **joint-stock money** (many investors share risk), **monopoly charters**, forts and armed ships.

e.g. Roy: **organisation mattered as much as guns**.

4. Europeans depended on Indians

Indian **bankers** (who minted coins and lent money, e.g. the **Jagatseths**), **brokers** (who bought cloth from weavers) and shipbuilders did most of the work. Relations mixed need and distrust.

e.g. The broker **Amirchand** plotted against the nawab Siraj ud-Daula in 1756; **Ananda Ranga Pillai**'s diary describes a broker's hard job.

5. Port towns: Madras, Bombay, Calcutta

Unlike Surat (where they were only tenants), here the English were **landlords**, with their own **laws, courts and forts**. Indian merchants moved in for safety.

e.g. Madras c.1640, Bombay c.1660, Calcutta c.1690.

6. From trade to empire

After **Aurangzeb died (1707)**, the Mughal empire broke up. The companies fought each other (Carnatic wars) and the English won Bengal: **Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764**.

e.g. Trade did not automatically cause empire, but it **created the conditions** for it.

Chaudhuri
Big theory · whole civilisations · very long time (622–1750) · connection as an **idea**

vs

Roy
Facts and economics · merchants, companies, ports · 1500–1800 · connection as **trade practice**

Lecture: they **complement** each other. **Limitation of the "connected space" idea:** it can hide inequality, slavery and force, and focus on merchants rather than peasants and workers. Ask **"connected for whom?"**

WRITE IT LIKE THIS (ESSAY OUTLINE, 15 MARKS)

Q. "European expansion transformed, but did not create, Indian Ocean connectivity." Discuss.

Intro: "Connected space" means structured interaction across distance, not sameness. The Indian Ocean was connected long before 1500.

Before Europe: monsoon trade from Baghdad to Canton with India at the centre (Bernstein); monks on merchant ships (Sen); Tamil temples from Java to Quanzhou (Guy). Chaudhuri shows "unity in the large" across four civilisations from 622.

Europeans arrive: the Portuguese (1498) used violence and passes but never fully controlled trade. The EIC and VOC brought joint-stock organisation, but still **depended on Indian bankers and brokers** (Roy).

Transformation: port towns (Madras, Bombay, Calcutta) with their own law; Mughal decline after 1707; Plassey and Buxar turned trade into **empire**.

But: connection was unequal (force, slavery, coerced weavers). "Connected for whom?"

Conclusion: Europe changed who held power, but the network itself was much older.

LAST

Night-Before Revision Sheet

Read this once tonight and once before the exam. One line per session, the names and dates for MCQs, and the questions most likely to come.

S	The one idea	Names + 1 example each
1	Societies use the past as **pattern → model → process**	**Hobsbawm** (1972) · Zapata · Warsaw = symbolic restoration
2	Find → check → interpret → explain; **compare** cases	**Droysen**'s 4 steps · **Lange** (CHA) · **Backerra** (diplomatic letters)
3	**Global** = connections; **regional** = inside. Use both	**Wallerstein** (core/periphery) · **Hall** (multiple globalizations) · da Gama at 3 scales
4	Orientalist → Colonial → Nationalist → Marxist → Cambridge / Subaltern	**Jones** 1784 · **Mill** 1818 · **Jayaswal** · **Kosambi** · **Guha** 1982 · **Said** 1978
6	Travel writing = evidence + opinion → **corroborate**	**Faxian**, **Xuanzang** (Harsha, Nalanda), **Yijing** · al-Shahrastani vs al-Biruni
7	Monsoon trade = **premodern globalisation**, India at the centre	**Bernstein** · Gujarat/Cambay · Malacca (84 languages) · Zheng He 1405–33
8	No single Silk Road; **city lens vs region lens**	**Hansen** (Chang'an, Sogdians) · **Bhattacharya** (Bengal, cotton, cowries) · BRI 2013
9	Buddhism went **by sea with merchants**; "maritime Silk Road" is misleading	**Tansen Sen** · transit zone · Srivijaya · Sri Lanka relics · Atisa
10	Religion is plural, lived, and **changes as it travels**	**Madan** (plurality ≠ pluralism) · **Guy** (Purnavarman) · **Ray** (Nagapattinam)
11	Unity in the large, disunity in the small; **trade → empire**	**Chaudhuri** (622–1750, 4 civilisations) · **Roy** (EIC, brokers, Madras/Bombay/Calcutta)

Dates worth remembering (MCQs + answers)

325 BC	Chandragupta date ("sheet anchor", Jones)
399–413	Faxian's journey
629–645	Xuanzang in India (met Harsha)
622	Rise of Islam (Chaudhuri's start)
750	Abbasids, Baghdad
878	Huang Chao massacre at Canton
c.450	Purnavarman's Vishnu footprint (Java)
1281	Tamil–Chinese Shiva temple inscription, Quanzhou
1405–33	Zheng He's voyages
1498	Vasco da Gama at Calicut
1511	Portuguese take Malacca
1600 / 1602	English EIC / Dutch VOC
1707	Aurangzeb dies; Mughal breakup
1757 / 1764	Plassey / Buxar
1784	Asiatic Society (William Jones)
1818	James Mill's *History of British India*
1871	Colonial census categories begin
1877	"Silk Road" named (Richthofen)
1972 / 1982	Hobsbawm's essay / Subaltern Studies
2013 / 2014	China's BRI / India's Act East

Most likely questions (prepare these)

SHORT ANSWERS (10 MARKS)

1. Doctrine vs lived religion (S10) **(model answer given in class)**
2. Pattern, model, process (S1)
3. Usefulness of foreign travellers; al-Shahrastani vs al-Biruni (S6)
4. Hansen vs Bhattacharya: "no single Silk Road" (S8)
5. Why "maritime Silk Road" is misleading; monks and merchants (S9)
6. Why India was central to Indian Ocean trade (S7)
7. Global vs regional history (S3)
8. Plurality vs pluralism (S10)

ESSAYS (15 MARKS)

1. Was Marxist "new history" an advance over colonial and nationalist history? (S4) **(model essay given in class)**
2. Europe transformed but did not create Indian Ocean connectivity (S7 + S9 + S10 + S11)
3. "Religion travelled because people travelled" (S9 + S10)
4. "Unity in the large, disunity in the small": Chaudhuri and Roy (S11)

Essay shape: intro with a thesis → 3–4 paragraphs, each = one point + scholar + example → one "but" paragraph → conclusion linking to "India was connected long before Europe".

5 SENTENCES YOU CAN DROP INTO ALMOST ANY ANSWER

1. "The past is a permanent dimension of human consciousness" (Hobsbawm): every age rewrites it for its own needs.
2. Every source is both evidence and interpretation, so historians must corroborate.
3. The scale we choose (city, region, ocean, globe) decides what we see.
4. Asia was connected long before 1500; Europe transformed but did not create that world.
5. Religion travelled because people travelled, and it was translated, not simply copied.